Address to a Joint Session of Congress and the American People

President George W. Bush · September 20, 2001

Source: U.S. National Archives, archives.gov; whitehouse.gov archived release.

Nine days after the September 11, 2001 attacks, Bush addressed Congress and outlined what would become the War on Terror. He demanded that the Taliban turn over al Qaeda leaders, announced the creation of the Office of Homeland Security, and framed the conflict as a global struggle of 'freedom' versus 'fear.' The address is widely remembered for its high popular approval (Bush hit 90% approval) but also marks the start of a policy era that produced the USA PATRIOT Act, the war in Afghanistan (2001), the war in Iraq (2003), and the Guantanamo detention regime.

Connect: The PATRIOT Act (2001) expanded surveillance and detention powers. Compare with EO 9066 in WWII (Class 50). Are these justified emergency measures or repeated overreach?

Key Passages

Demand on the Taliban

> Tonight, the United States of America makes the following demands on the Taliban: Deliver to United States authorities all the leaders of al Qaeda who hide in your land. … These demands are not open to negotiation or discussion. The Taliban must act, and act immediately. They will hand over the terrorists, or they will share in their fate.

'You are either with us'

> Every nation, in every region, now has a decision to make. Either you are with us, or you are with the terrorists. From this day forward, any nation that continues to harbor or support terrorism will be regarded by the United States as a hostile regime.

On American character

> I will not forget this wound to our country or those who inflicted it. I will not yield. I will not rest. … The course of this conflict is not known, yet its outcome is certain. Freedom and fear, justice and cruelty, have always been at war, and we know that God is not neutral between them.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	Nine days after the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks killed nearly 3,000 people, with the nation in shock and grief.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, the American public, the Taliban, and nations around the world.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President George W. Bush, a Republican rallying the nation and defining the response; critics of the coming war and civil-liberties concerns are not heard.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — civil liberties post-9/11: Identify ONE specific way Americans' civil liberties changed after 2001 and explain that change.

2. Compare the 'with us or against us' framing to earlier wartime presidential rhetoric.

3. Why did Bush focus on Afghanistan rather than Iraq in this 2001 speech?